

Forensic Incident Response/Capstone

CYFI 750/490

Instructor

Dr. Frank (Weifeng) Xu

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Office hours: By appointment

Class Information

Credits: 3 credits

Lecture time: Th 17:30–21:15

Location: BC 015 (in person); Zoom (online)

Zoom: [Join the online class](#)

<https://ubalt.zoom.us/j/5547149563>

This syllabus and related course instructions are available at https://github.com/frankwxu/public_space.

Course Description

This course integrates and applies the knowledge, theories, principles, skills, and practical applications learned in the Master of Science in Forensic Science—Cyber Investigations program to actual cybercrime case scenarios.

Prerequisite: Successful completion of all core courses in the program and permission from the program director.

Meeting Format

The course meets every Thursday and is offered in two formats:

- **Hybrid (HYB):** In-person attendance on campus is required on September 17 and October 1, 15, and 29; all remaining lectures will be held remotely via Zoom.
- **Zoom (ZM):** Remote attendance via Zoom is required for all class sessions.

Student Learning Outcomes

- Survey cybercrime scenarios, key cybercrime activities, and digital evidence associated with the activities.
- Mimic cybercrime activities in a controlled environment.
- Design forensic approaches and practice techniques to acquire snapshots of computing systems.
- Apply an evidence-based approach to systematically re-create cybercrime scenarios.
- Develop comprehensive cyber investigation reports.

Textbook

- **Optional:** Xu, Weifeng, Lin Deng, and Mohit Dhabuwala. 2025. *Digital Forensics Basics: A Step-by-Step Guide for Beginners: An Open-Source Approach* (Second Edition). Kindle edition. August 1. Amazon. <https://www.amazon.com/dp/B0HH8WQSMK>.
- **Optional textbook:** *Incident Response & Computer Forensics*, McGraw-Hill Education, 3rd edition, Jason T. Luttgens, Matthew Pepe, and Kevin Mandia, ISBN 978-0071798686, 2014.
- **Supplemental PDF:** [Digital Forensics PDF](#). **Access:** Available to enrolled students.

Course Topics (Tentative)

Introduction

1. Course Overview
2. Basic Computer Skills (Linux)

Mobile Investigation

3. Android Device and Images
4. Device and System Investigation
5. Application Life Cycle
6. AOSP App Investigation

Midterm

7. GMS App Investigation – Messaging
8. GMS App Investigation – Dialer
9. GMS App Investigation – Map/Photo
10. GMS App Investigation – Kik/TextNow
11. GMS App Investigation – WhatsApp
12. Other Topics (iOS) – Optional
13. Other Topics (IoT) – Optional
14. Final Exam Presentation

Grading Criteria

Lab/Projects/Homework/Quizzes: 200 points

Midterm: 100 points

Final: 100 points

Total: 400 points

Grade thresholds: A: 95%; A-: 90%; B+: 87%; B: 83%; B-: 80%; C+: 77%; C: 73%; C-: 70%; F: below 70%.

Potential Grade Adjustments for Active Engagement: Final grades near the next higher letter-grade threshold (e.g., 89% or 89.5% near the 90% threshold for an A-) may be considered for a **discretionary upgrade**. Adjustments are not guaranteed and depend on the instructor's assessment of your overall active engagement during Zoom sessions. Examples include keeping your camera on during group discussions, regularly contributing via audio, or consistently participating.

Grade policy

- **Late submissions:** Late homework, quizzes, and labs will not be accepted for credit.
- **Attendance:** Missing two or more class sessions will result in a failing course grade.
- **Make-up assessments:** Make-up quizzes and exams require prior arrangements with the instructor.
- **Technical questions:** When emailing a technical question, include relevant screenshots, the commands you used, and the steps you took to verify your results.
- **Grade appeals:** Submit grade appeals by email within two weeks of receiving the grade. Appeals submitted after this deadline will not be considered.
- **Grade calculation:** Final course percentages are calculated by dividing points earned by total available points and multiplying by 100.

Appeal a Grade

When appealing a grade, it is important to provide a clear and well-justified reason for why the grade should be re-evaluated. Use the following template and include relevant supporting reasons.

[Your Name]
[Your Student ID]
[Course Name and Number]
[Date]

1. **Detailed Explanation of the Issue:** Clearly and concisely describe the specific aspect(s) of your work that you believe were not accurately assessed or graded. Be as specific as possible and refer to relevant sections of your assignment or exam.
2. **Providing Supporting Evidence:** Attach or reference relevant materials, such as rubrics, assignment guidelines, or notes from class discussions, that demonstrate your understanding of the subject matter and your adherence to the assignment requirements.
3. **Comparative Analysis:** Compare your work to the grading criteria and any exemplary solutions or model answers that were provided. Highlight areas where you believe your work meets or exceeds the expectations outlined in the course.

4. **Addressing Feedback:** If you received feedback from the initial grading, explain how you have incorporated that feedback into your work and why you believe it should lead to a higher grade.
5. **Clarity in Communication:** Ensure your appeal is well-organized, concise, and respectful in tone. Clearly articulate your points and avoid unnecessary emotional language.
6. **Meeting Deadlines:** Check the institution's policies regarding grade appeals and deadlines. Make sure your appeal is submitted within the specified timeframe.

Other Important Information

Academic Calendar and Important Dates

<https://www.ubalt.edu/academics/classes-and-registration/academic-calendar.cfm>

Recording Statement

Faculty may be required to record classes for the purposes of accommodating a disability or may opt to do so for students who cannot attend or who wish to review the full class content. All recordings are for the sole use of class instruction and study and may not be reproduced by students for any other purpose; to do so is a conduct violation. Faculty cannot reproduce students' voices or images from the class for any other purpose without additional student consent. All such recordings are protected by a UB login process based on where they are posted. Students may mute their microphone or turn off their camera if they do not consent to be recorded, but this may mean they need to find additional ways to participate in class. Faculty are to notify students when a class is recorded.

Students can use a virtual background on Zoom to protect their privacy while remaining clearly in attendance and engaged in class. Students should keep in mind that faculty have to be able to determine if a student is truly participating in a class to comply with University and federal attendance policies. A student could be deemed absent if logged in to a synchronous class but not responding. Visual and/or audio presence may be required for examinations or other types of assessment.